A Midsummer Night's Dream: Plot Summary

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Plot Summary

One of the most important things you can do in preparation for the exam is to know the plot of A Midsummer Night's Dream thoroughly. Once you know the play well, you should be comfortable and familiar enough with key events that you can then link to themes and Shakepeare's use of dramatic techniques. Having an in-depth knowledge and understanding of the text will help you to gain confidence when choosing the most relevant references to support your response.

Below you will find:

- an overview of the play
- a scene-by-scene plot summary

Overview

A Midsummer Night's Dream is a five-act comedy written by William Shakespeare in 1595–1596. The story is set in Athens and also takes place in a forest.

The play begins with the Duke of Athens, Theseus, who is discussing his future wedding with his fiance, Hippolyta. He is interrupted by an angry nobleman, Egeus. He is outraged that his daughter, Hermia, refuses to marry Demetrius as she is in love with another man called Lysander. She is told that she must either marry her father's choice or face the consequences. Lysander and Hermia decide to **elope** that night and set out for the forest.

Hermia's friend Helena is in love with Demetrius but he does not reciprocate her feelings. Helena tells him that Hermia and Lysander plan to elope in the hope that this will make him fall in love with her. Demetrius sets off to the forest to stop the lovers and Helena follows.

Meanwhile, a group of tradesmen are planning to perform a play during the Duke's wedding and are rehearsing the play in the same forest.

In another location in the forest, Oberon, the fairy king, jealously argues with Titania, his queen, over a little boy that

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

so that she falls in love with the first thing she sees when she wakes up.

Help me understand

Oberon also witnesses Demetrius arguing with Helena and so orders Puck to use the magic plant on Demetrius's eyes to make him fall in love with Helena. However, Puck mistakenly puts the liquid on Lysander's eyes; he promptly rejects Hermia and falls madly in love with Helena. Puck also transforms Bottom's head into a donkey's and Titania wakes up and falls in love with him.

Confusion **ensues** as Lysander and Demetrius are both chasing Helena, who thinks they are **mocking** her. Hermia is hurt and confused and becomes angry at Helena.

Eventually, Oberon's anger **dissipates** and he lifts the enchantment and helps Puck fix his mistakes. After getting lost in the woods separately, the four young lovers fall asleep. Titania reconciles with Oberon. The Duke and Hippolyta are hunting in the woods and find the four Athenians asleep. Upon waking, they do not remember very much of the night before but Lysander loves Hermia and Demetrius loves Helena. The Duke takes pity on them and agrees that they should all marry. Bottom and the Mechanicals perform their play in front of the Duke and the couples

The fairies visit the couples as they sleep and bless their unions. The play then ends with Puck, who asks the audience to think of the play as merely a dream and to applaud if they enjoyed the performance.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

While it is important to know and understand the plot, it is just as important that you pay attention to the stage directions Shakespeare uses. These give extra information about the action and the characters, which will help you to develop your own insights and interpretations about the play.

Act-By-Act Plot Summary

Act I

- We are introduced to the Duke, Theseus and his betrothed, Hippolyta, who are preparing for their wedding in a few days
- Egeus, a nobleman, complains to the Duke about his daughter, Hermia, who refuses to marry Demetrius
- Hermia decides to elope with her love, Lysander, and they agree to meet at the forest
- Another character, Helena, is in love with Demetrius but he is pursuing Hermia
- Helena tells Demetrius that Hermia is planning to elope and he goes to the forest to find the couple; Helena

Act II

- In the forest, the fairy king argues with his queen Titania over a little Indian boy who Titania is caring for
- Angry, Oberon orders Puck to find a magical flower that makes a person fall in love with the first thing they see when they wake up
- Oberon places the juice from the flower on Titania's eyes while she sleeps in her bower
- Oberon witnesses Demetrius's anger towards Helena and decides to make him fall in love with her
- Puck obeys Oberon's orders but mistakes Lysander for Demetrius, accidentally putting the magical plant on his eyes as he sleeps
- Lysander wakes up and falls in love with Helena, abandoning Hermia

Act III

- The group of actors are rehearsing and Puck transforms Nick Bottom's head into a donkey's head:
    - The other actors run away and Bottom chases them
- He ends up where Titania is sleeping and when she wakes, she falls in love with Bottom as a result of the enchanted flower
- Oberon realises that Puck has put the potion on the wrong man and makes Puck find Demetrius to put the potion on Demetrius's eyes
- Demetrius wakes up and falls in love with Helena but Helena thinks he is also making fun of her
- Hermia threatens Helena while Demetrius and Lysander agree to duel
- Oberon tells Puck to prevent the duel and to lift the spell on Lysander while he goes to help Titania
- Eventually, all four lovers tire and fall asleep
- Puck lifts the spell on Lysander so that he will wake up in love with Hermia again

Act IV

- Oberon removes the spell from Titania so that she is no longer in love with Bottom:
    - He asks Puck to transform Bottom's head back to normal so that, when he wakes, he can return to Athens with the other four lovers
- Morning arrives and the sleeping four are woken by Theseus and his group
- They do not remember anything of the previous night and Demetrius confesses his love for Helena
- The Duke overrides Egeus's wishes and announces that the couples may be with whoever they wish
- Bottom wakes up and thinks that he dreamt everything that happened to him during the night:
    - He does not tell anyone about what he experienced as he is too busy preparing for the performance

Act V

- Theseus and Hippolyta talk about what the four lovers, Demetrius, Helena, Lysander and Hermia, told them

enter and bless the couples

Epilogue

Puck addresses the audience and asks them to remember the play as a dream. He wishes the audience a good night and asks them to applaud.

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